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CHAPTER 2

EXPANSION OF THE ENGLISH EAST INDIA COMPANY IN INDIA (Part-1)

Conquest of Bengal (1756–1772)

Introduction

Bengal was the **richest province** of the Mughal Empire. It included present-day **West Bengal, Bihar, Odisha and Bangladesh**. The English East India Company wanted to control Bengal because it was a major centre of trade and wealth. Their victory in Bengal laid the foundation of British rule in India.

Bengal before British Rule

Before the British captured Bengal, it was one of the wealthiest regions in Asia.

Important Facts

- Bengal included **present-day West Bengal, Bihar, Odisha and Bangladesh**.
- It was the **richest province** of the Mughal Empire.
- Bengal exported **silk, cotton textiles, sugar, rice, indigo, pepper and saltpetre** to Europe.
- Nearly **60% of British imports from Asia** came from Bengal.
- The Nawabs of Bengal opposed the special trade privileges enjoyed by the English Company.

Nawabs of Bengal

Alivardi Khan

Alivardi Khan became the Nawab after defeating Sarfaraz Khan.

Important Facts

- In **1741**, Alivardi Khan defeated **Sarfaraz Khan**.
- He became the **Subahdar (Governor) of Bengal**.
- He died in **April 1756**.
- He was succeeded by his grandson **Siraj-ud-Daulah**.

Siraj-ud-Daulah

Siraj-ud-Daulah became Nawab of Bengal in 1756.

Important Facts

- Opposed the growing power of the English.
- Objected to the English fortifying Calcutta without his permission.
- Captured the English fort at Calcutta.
- His conflict with the English led to the **Battle of Plassey**.

Black Hole Tragedy

The capture of Calcutta increased tension between the English and Siraj-ud-Daulah.

Important Facts

- According to the source, **146 English prisoners** were locked in a small room.
- **123 prisoners** died due to suffocation.
- The English used this incident as a reason to attack Siraj-ud-Daulah.

Battle of Plassey (1757)

The Battle of Plassey was the first major victory of the English in India.

Important Facts

- Date: **23 June 1757**
- Fought between **Siraj-ud-Daulah** and the **English East India Company**.
- English army was led by **Robert Clive**.
- Robert Clive secretly made agreements with some officers of the Nawab.
- The English won the battle.
- This battle is considered the **starting point of British rule in India**.

Secret Allies of Robert Clive

The English won because several important people supported them secretly.

Important Facts

- **Mir Jafar** – Commander of the Nawab's army.
- **Rai Durlabh**
- **Jagat Seth** – Banker of Bengal.
- **Manik Chand**

- **Amichand (Omichand)**
- **Khadim Khan**

After the Battle of Plassey

Important Facts

- **Mir Jafar** became the Nawab of Bengal with British support.
- Later, Mir Jafar resigned in favour of his son-in-law **Mir Kasim**.

Mir Kasim

Mir Kasim tried to free Bengal from British control.

Important Facts

- He opposed the misuse of trade privileges by the English.
- He formed an alliance with:
 - **Shuja-ud-Daulah** (Nawab of Awadh)
 - **Shah Alam II** (Mughal Emperor)
- This alliance led to the **Battle of Buxar**.

Battle of Buxar (1764)

The Battle of Buxar gave the English complete political control over Bengal.

Important Facts

- Date: **22 October 1764**
- English army was led by **Major Hector Munro**.
- Opponents:
 - Mir Kasim
 - Shuja-ud-Daulah
 - Shah Alam II
- The English defeated the combined army.
- This battle gave the English real political power in North India.

After the Battle of Buxar

Important Facts

- Mir Jafar again became Nawab of Bengal.
- After Mir Jafar's death, **Najim-ud-Daulah** became Nawab.
- In **August 1765**, Robert Clive signed **two Treaties of Allahabad**:

- One with the Nawab of Awadh.
- One with Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II.

Dual Government in Bengal (1765–1772)

After the Battle of Buxar, the Company controlled Bengal but kept the Nawab as a nominal ruler.

Important Facts

- Introduced by **Robert Clive**.
- Started in **1765**.
- Company controlled:
 - **Diwani** (Revenue collection)
 - **Nizamat** (Police and Judicial functions)
- Deputy Diwans:
 - **Mohammad Reza Khan** – Bengal
 - **Raja Sitab Roy** – Bihar
- Nawab **Najim-ud-Daulah** had only administrative powers.
- In **1772**, **Warren Hastings** abolished the Dual Government and took full control of Bengal.

Important Personalities

Personality	Importance
Alivardi Khan	Nawab of Bengal before Siraj-ud-Daulah
Siraj-ud-Daulah	Nawab defeated in the Battle of Plassey
Robert Clive	Led the English at Plassey; introduced Dual Government
Mir Jafar	Nawab after the Battle of Plassey
Mir Kasim	Opposed the British; fought at Buxar
Major Hector Munro	Led the English at the Battle of Buxar
Shuja-ud-Daulah	Nawab of Awadh; fought against the English
Shah Alam II	Mughal Emperor; fought at Buxar
Mohammad Reza Khan	Deputy Diwan of Bengal
Raja Sitab Roy	Deputy Diwan of Bihar
Warren Hastings	Abolished the Dual Government in 1772

Important Places

Place	Importance
Bengal	Richest province of the Mughal Empire

Calcutta	Captured by Siraj-ud-Daulah
Plassey	Battle fought in 1757
Buxar	Battle fought in 1764
Allahabad	Treaties signed by Robert Clive
Bihar	Part of Bengal province

Important Battles & Treaties

Name	Importance
Battle of Plassey (1757)	Beginning of British rule in India
Battle of Buxar (1764)	Established British political power
Treaties of Allahabad (1765)	Signed by Robert Clive after Buxar

Important Years

Year	Event
	1741 Alivardi Khan became Nawab
	1756 Siraj-ud-Daulah became Nawab
23 June 1757	Battle of Plassey
22 October 1764	Battle of Buxar
	1765 Treaties of Allahabad and Dual Government
	1772 Dual Government abolished

Frequently Confused Facts

Question	Correct Answer
Richest Mughal province	Bengal
Beginning of British rule	Battle of Plassey (1757)
Real political foundation of British power	Battle of Buxar (1764)
Leader of English at Plassey	Robert Clive
Leader of English at Buxar	Major Hector Munro
Introduced Dual Government	Robert Clive
Abolished Dual Government	Warren Hastings
Deputy Diwan of Bengal	Mohammad Reza Khan
Deputy Diwan of Bihar	Raja Sitab Roy